Ajmi, a retired squadron leader of the Oman Air Force and a Qatari national. Ajmi was also arrested, but released on bail in November 2022. The eight Indians—Captain Saurabh Vashisht, Commander Purnendu Tiwari, Captain Birendra Kumar Verma, Commander Sugunakar Pakala, Commander Sanjeev Gupta, Commander Amit Nagpal and Sailor Ragesh—are said to have had an 'impeccable' record while serving in the Indian navy for up to two decades and took voluntary retirement after holding important positions. Commander Tiwari was awarded the Pravasi Bharatiya Samman—the highest honour conferred on overseas Indians—in 2019.

AN SOS MISSION

- **Charged with espionage, eight former Indian Navy personnel were sentenced to death in Qatar**
- **The MEA assured their families that India will take up the issue**
- **India can appeal the verdict in a Qatar court or the ICJ, and use diplomatic means**

Notably, Qatar, though a US ally, is one of Hamas's main backers and shares frosty relations with Israel. Naturally, closer New Delhi-Tel Aviv ties may not have gone down well in Doha. India's initial support to Israel after it was attacked by Hamas may not have been liked too. South Block mandarins suspect the West Asian conflict has complicated any future talks with Qatar and expect it to be a long haul, with formidable challenges, especially so with the impending Lok Sabha polls. Besides challenging the death verdict legally, India will also work through back-door diplomatic channels, probably bringing to bear its influence with other West Asian nations.

The obvious legal option for India is to appeal against the verdict in a higher Qatari court. The families may also move a mercy petition to the Emir of Qatar, who has the right to pardon prisoners on death row. An official says that apart from one Nepali migrant worker in 2021, no other death penalty has been carried out in Qatar in the last 20 years. That offers hope. Moreover, there is the option to approach the International Court of Justice, which India did in the case of Kulbhushan Jadhav, who faces a death sentence in Pakistan on spying charges. Besides, during Qatar's Emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani's visit to India in 2015, both sides had signed multiple agreements, including one on prisoner repatriation. The pact allowed citizens of India and Qatar, who had been convicted of crimes, to be extradited to their home country to serve out their sentences. All that's in sync with the warm ties New Delhi enjoys with Doha historically. India was among the few countries that recognised Qatar soon after its independence in 1971. The two nations established full diplomatic relations in 1973, and 2023 marks 50 years of diplomatic ties. Around 800,000 Indians live and work in Qatar, and defence and strategic cooperation between the two nations is on a positive trajectory.

On October 30, after meeting the families of the convicted Indians, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar wrote on X: "Fully share the concerns and pain of the families. Underlined that the government will continue to make all efforts to secure their release." The challenge for him is to accomplish that smoothly. ■

By Amarnath K. Menon

The assembly ection may be more than six months away, but the political climate is already heating up in Andhra Pradesh. On October 31, Telugu Desam Party (TDP) president N. Chandrababu Naidu walked out of the Rajamahendravaram Central Prison after nearly two months, within hours of the Andhra Pradesh High Court granting him a four-week interim bail on medical grounds. The former chief minister, who was in jail since September 10, is accused of siphoning off funds running into crores of rupees that were meant to train unemployed youths during his last tenure (2014-19). Even as he received a hero's welcome from supporters en route to his residence, Naidu's troubles are far from over. For, on October 28, the Andhra Pradesh Crime Investigation Department had registered another graft case against him involving licences issued to certain distilleries when he was the CM.

With Naidu's fate unclear, the TDP has already devised a Plan B to take on the ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) in the assembly as well as general elections, set to be conducted simultaneously next summer. On October 25, Nara Bhuvaneswari, Naidu's wife and daughter of the late TDP founder N.T. Rama Rao, had set out on a yatra with the slogan 'Nijam Gelavali', that is, 'Truth must triumph', in support of her husband. Bhuvaneswari, who has so far stayed aloof from politics, began her tour from Naravaripalle, Naidu's native village, on a sentimental note after garlanding an NTR statue. The party claimed the tour is to console the families of supporters who purportedly died in the wake of Naidu's arrest and prolonged detention.

But the yatra has a familiar ring to it. Chief Minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy banked on a similar 'odarpu yatra' (condolence tour), visiting the families of those who had reportedly died of shock after his father and then CM Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy was killed in a chopper crash in 2009, to springboard into state politics. The TDP hopes that Bhuvaneswari's yatra, which has been put on hold for now, will elicit a similar response from the electorate.